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Hal Smith

Hal Smith was born in Indianapolis on July 30, 1953. He grew up in California and started on the drums at age ten. Jake Hanna was an early teacher, but Hal learned his craft mostly from the recordings of Nick Fatool and Ben Pollack. Hal has played behind many stars of mainstream jazz, including Bob Wilber, Doc Cheatham, Jim Cullum and Milt Hinton. Recordings for Arbors, Stomp Off and Good Time Jazz further enhanced his reputation and he expanded his skills into writing about jazz for The Mississippi Rag. *Hal is the leader of the Road Runners with Rebecca Kilgore, and has toured Germany with his band Swing Cats.*

Hal was interviewed on September 12, 1997 at the Allegheny Jazz Festival in Chautauqua, New York by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are talking today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive with band leader and drummer Hal Smith here in Chautauqua, New York. And thank you for joining us.

HS: Glad to be here.

MR: We were talking before the cameras were rolling about your current state of flux — you just moved and you're on your way to Europe. What's going on in Europe for you?

HS: It's a three week tour of playing medical trade shows.

MR: No kidding?

HS: Where doctors and company representatives from pharmaceutical companies discuss new products, and the agent who brought the band over discusses creativity and marketing the products, and to illustrate creativity, he has a jazz band there to improvise.

MR: I'm fascinated by that.

HS: Me too.

MR: That's really interesting.

HS: It is. And this is the fourth year I've been doing these tours.

MR: And who do you take with you?

HS: I'm a sideman on this one, which is great. When you go overseas you don't have to worry about any of the leader's problems, you're just a sideman. But I'm working for Tim Laughlin, who is a great clarinetist from New Orleans, and a protégé of Pete Fountain.

MR: So how do they — he works into his presentation the idea of improvising or ensemble —

HS: Yes. This is a new product. You can market it to the public this way, and it that doesn't work, think on your feet, just like this jazz band's about to do. That kind of thing. And it works, almost every time. And I've gone over a couple of times with my own group, the California Swing Cats for the same company, but different products each time.

MR: So you're playing in Germany.

HS: Switzerland this time.

MR: Switzerland.

HS: Yes.

MR: Is it mostly for Swiss people, or is it kind of a big conference where people come from.

HS: No. It will be Swiss medical people, almost exclusively. And maybe a couple from Austria or Germany or neighboring countries, because some of them have heard the bands before and they like to be invited to these "trend meetings" they call them, so they can hear the band again. We've even seen some of them at performances over here when they come to the States, so they come to New Orleans or something and make a point to look up the musicians they've heard.

MR: That's great. It's great that they picked jazz to do it too.

HS: Yes, it sure is.

MR: I don't know what else they would pick.

HS: I don't want to think about it.

MR: Don't even put the idea in their minds.

HS: I'm not.

MR: Well you started out — was drums your first instrument?

HS: No. That's what I wound up with. I started with banjo, then piano, clarinet, trombone, and I'd probably still be playing that if I didn't have to have braces. And drums was something convenient to play that your teeth can be bound up and it doesn't really matter. And I just stayed with drums. With a crystal ball, I'd go back to trombone.

MR: Oh, no kidding.

HS: Yeah.

MR: A little bit easier to move around.

HS: That doesn't bother me at all. I just like the trombone and I have a way I'd like to hear it sound, and I don't hear it that often and I wish I could do it.

MR: Yeah. There's not a lot of young trombone players out there right now it doesn't seem like, that the instrument is that much in fashion.

HS: Not in the traditional and swing mode. There are some fine modern players, or clinicians, but not fellows who play real old style.

MR: I see you had some association with Jake Hanna early on.

HS: Yes, sure did. Not too early really. I'd been playing quite a while before I took lessons from him. And my early studies were with a pretty generic drum teacher, who said you play a quarter note this way, and do this this way, and do that that way. But despite that he still told me some wrong techniques, and it took Jake Hanna to turn my technique around or I'd still be playing wrong.

MR: Did you have the —

HS: I never played matched grip. But I didn't have my left hand far enough over, like the old time drummers did. And that's the first thing Jake Hanna said. "Nope, not far enough over." "I can't do that." It took forever. But I'm glad. But I've picked up a lot — not so much from the lessons as just from watching him play, watching the techniques he uses and how he tunes the drums, and the height he sits, and where he has his equipment and all that. That was as useful to me as the lessons.

MR: He's still playing?

HS: He sure is.

MR: In fact I think we're going to see him in a couple of weeks in Aspen.

HS: I hope so. He's an absolutely terrific player to play in any style band and make it sound better than it already does.

MR: Who else was influencing you when you were developing on the drums?

HS: Nick Fatool was one who was comfortable in either a studio setting or a swing band or a big band or a lot of Dixieland bands with Matty Matlock, Eddie Miller, Dick Cathcart, the people who played in Southern California, such on the soundtrack of "Pete Kelly's Blues" and Matty Matlock's "Paducah Patrol," and the Rampart Street Paraders and I think Nick Fatool, if you took a survey of musicians, maybe twenty musicians like the ones here this weekend and said who's your favorite drummer, probably eighteen of them would say Nick Fatool.

MR: No kidding.

HS: Yeah. Because he just is such a marvelous technician, but he doesn't let it get in the way of swinging, and he's always got perfect taste.

MR: If you had to — tough question number one, okay — if you had a young drummer, defining swing, can you do it in words?

HS: It's a feeling of lightness and elasticity and working with the other members of the rhythm section, where it's a joint effort to move forward, but it's not tense. It doesn't fall back on the beat. It can get in the groove, but it doesn't just sit there, it keeps moving. But not too far ahead and not too far behind. That's the ideal I think.

MR: Playing ahead of the beat, and playing behind the beat — is this something that exists for you?

HS: Sure.

MR: This concept.

HS: Depending on the band. I try to scope out a rhythm section right away. And if I can hear one guy, if the bass is turned way up, and he's going to have it his way or no way, I'm not going to fight him. Because then we're going to drown out everybody on the horns, and they're going to be mad at both of us. So I'll try and work with him. If he's going to work with me, or if there's no amp, or if everybody's trying to make a group effort out of

it, then sometimes I'll lead the way. I have to know who I'm working with. If it's people I don't work with all the time, like Dave McKenna this weekend, I haven't worked with him for a long time. I listen to him. I didn't want to put my foot on his chest and say okay, here's where it is. I want him to be comfortable. If it's someone I work with all the time, they know what I do anyway, and they're probably going to wait for me to lay it down.

MR: Bass players, do they tend to try to work with you, like the gentlemen that you're working with this weekend. Do you feel that the two of them are any different?

HS: Well I haven't played with Michael Moore yet. I will do that tonight. And I've only played with him once and that was at this jazz party when it was still in Pennsylvania, about 1985. That won't be any problem. He's a real light bass player.

MR: He's very light.

HS: It's going to work out fine. I have no question. The difference will be the piano, because Dave Frishberg was on the original recording that we're supposed to be recreating. So of course he's not here, and there's no drums on the recording. So I'm going to be a real outlander there. But I'm not going to take charge of that rhythm section. I'm going to let those guys play as they would without a drummer, and just try and play lightly in the background. With Bob Haggart though, he lays down, he picks the time. So I've gone with him all weekend.

MR: That acoustic guitar makes a big difference too.

HS: It really does.

MR: It's such a — we almost forget how tied that was to the Basie thing.

HS: Yes. And not just Basie. Eddie Condon. People forget what a good guitar player he was. Not a soloist, but the time was as perfect as it could get. And it's a lost art now, it really is, except at functions like this. Big bands don't use rhythm guitar anymore.

MR: Yeah. It seems to be something about the acoustic thing too.

HS: Yeah.

MR: Because it's percussive.

HS: Yes it is.

MR: It's almost like you're not hearing the chord as much as you are the — almost the washboard effect.

HS: It depends on who's playing it. Some players mute the strings, some let them ring. With Marty Grosz you hear the ring of the strings, which is nice. Like that's the way Eddie Condon played. And with Rebecca Kilgore, she lets the strings ring. And it's just a nice blend, especially with an acoustic bass. If there's not lots of micing, that guitar, you can key everything on the rhythm guitar. You sure don't want to be fighting that if it's

playing all four beats. Easier for me to back off a little bit than for the guitar, so you don't have that. And those two are two of the easiest to work with I can think of.

MR: You were born in '53.

HS: Yes.

MR: How come you didn't go the rock & roll route?

HS: When I was a kid I was growing up at the very end of the Dixieland revival, started by Lu Watters and Turk Murphy, including Bunk Johnson, Kid Ory. And the second wave of that was honky tonk piano and banjo, barber shop quartets. That was real popular when I was a kid, all over the radio, on the T.V.

MR: In Indianapolis?

HS: Everywhere.

MR: Because we're similar in age, I'm a little older than you, but I was not aware that there was a revival of Dixieland at all.

HS: Well it was more pronounced in California. That was the hot bed of it, the Bay area, and Los Angeles to a lesser degree. But the bands that made it big, banjo bands or pianos to have a hit single, Crazy Otto, Johnny Maddox, Joe "Fingers" Carr, people like that, you could hear those things on the radio very easily and there were lots of recordings of "Waiting for the Robert E. Lee," "Alabama Jubilee," things like that. I mean, I could walk into any record store in Indianapolis and find those things.

MR: I'll be darned.

HS: So it was just kind of a happy music, and it wasn't a protest music like rock & roll. I heard Elvis Presley, I remember Bill Haley and the Comets and all that, it just never did anything for me. And I like ragtime and the banjo music and all that kind of thing, and that's what led me into an appreciation of Dixieland, when I finally, I heard the Firehouse Five at Disneyland, when we moved to California when I was eight. I was taken to Disneyland for my birthday, the first live jazz band I ever heard, that's it. That wiped out everything I'd heard before.

MR: And you were playing at that time, which instrument were you playing?

HS: I was not settled on anything. I'd gone from piano to banjo — I was playing clarinet, just reading out of the exercise book at that point. And I heard that and the trombone got my imagination, and I really wanted to play that but then the braces came.

MR: What was your parents' musical tastes like?

HS: They liked older popular music. I mean they were not jazz fans, record collectors, with a copy of Brian Rust to say, "Oh yeah that was recorded by Bix and Red Nichols." They just, if it was good, and well played, they liked it. So when I got an interest in the older forms of ragtime and things like that, they were ready for that and they liked it because they'd grown up during the Swing Era, which was just an extension of that if you want to

think of it in a straight line. My dad was a pianist, just a hobby pianist, not a professional, but he had records of Jelly Roll Morton and Fats Waller and I heard those things, they didn't get through to me until years later. But generally if I liked it, they'd like it. And they were real supportive of my goals and taking me to hear live jazz whenever possible. That was problem though. In California, you have to be 21 to get into a club, and they card like crazy. And you can't sneak in and drink a Coke. So unless something came to Disneyland or an outdoor concert or a pizza parlor or something like that, I couldn't hear it. And a lot of the New York and Chicago musicians didn't come out. Eddie Condon brought Pee Wee Russell to Disneyland the year I didn't go. I never heard either one of them in person. I missed a lot of the people — Max Kaminsky, Muggsy Spanier, Gene Krupa. I hardly heard any of the Swing Era drummers in person.

MR: What about Ben Pollack?

HS: I heard Pollack.

MR: Yeah?

HS: The first jazz festival I went to was Dixieland at Disneyland, in 1964, and Pollock had a band there. And through suppressed memory, now I remember what he sounded like. At the time it was too much for me to absorb but thinking back on it I'm remembering the details of what he played. And the more I hear him on recordings and tape I remember what he did.

MR: Some of those guys didn't even — they had a different way of setting up their drums, didn't they?

HS: They sure did, yeah. The older players tended to use larger bass drums, and maybe two tom-toms. Floor tom, two mounted toms, wood block, two cowbells, and the cymbals down low, snare drum toted way over, which is a hold over from marching bands, when it's slung over your shoulder you play like you would in a military band. But all the Chicago drummers learned rudiments and classical technique from drummers who had come out of that military and classical tradition. So they played like that and lifted their sticks way high off the drum and all that. And I still tilt mine over, it's much easier to play. I can't play it the other way now.

MR: Do you recall seeing — I think it's the Glenn Miller movie, and Ben Pollack is in it?

HS: Sure is, and the Benny Goodman Story too.

MR: He's in both of those?

HS: And he plays closed rolls and the hi-hat. Yeah. I remember him doing that. And a stick on the bass drum. That's a technique you don't see too much anymore. Keep a four beat going on the bass drum and play a little syncopation against it with either the left or the right stick. I'd do that this weekend but with that 18-inch bass drum I'll drop a stick reaching for it.

MR: Well gosh, you have a pretty good list of well known names you've played with. Milt Hinton and Bob Wilber and all those guys. Was most of that at festivals?

HS: Mostly things like this, like jazz party work and mix and match. There'll be one person hiring everybody who'll put together a set of musicians he thinks will work well together; 99% of the time they do. But that's where I've gotten to work with really great players like that. Because you know they travel in their own circles. And if they're going to need a drummer, they're going to call someone they're comfortable with who they work with all the time. But that's the great advantage for me having played these things, I get to work with them where I probably wouldn't otherwise if I've been half a continent away. You know I'm not in New York where I'm going to see them all the time. So I'm really pleased to have had those chances.

MR: Did you ever have a circumstance where it's been like a train wreck?

HS: Yes.

MR: Yes. Are you sure you want to think about that? And is it usually something inherent in the rhythm section that's not, like you said, someone's trying to dominate or just not —

HS: No. Because I haven't had many train wrecks with rhythm sections. It's been the horn players, who'll tell you one thing and then they forgot they told you that. Or, they want to control the rhythm section. It wasn't a train wreck, but it was a very nerve wracking experience, I played with an individual who shall remain nameless, who was feature-billed with another Swing Era musician who shall also remain nameless. And there was a slight battle of the egos before the concert and it translated into telling the rhythm section how to play. And nothing we did was right. And one of these guys has written extensively about Dave Tough, who is one of my great heroes on the drums, and I thought here's my chance — Dave Tough, that's what I'm going to do all night. So I tried to play real subtly on the first tune, and he waves it to a halt and he said, "Play like you're playing in a 200-piece band."

MR: Oh, wow. He stopped the tune and did that?

HS: Yeah.

MR: Was this in a club?

HS: A concert.

MR: Oh, God.

HS: So I did. I played like I was building a house. And that's what he wanted. But then I heard another concert later where he was complaining about, "All drummers are house builders." I was only following orders.

MR: So there you go.

HS: What are you going to do? But then, for every experience like that there's Doc Cheatham, or Milt Hinton. And you walk off the bandstand thinking boy I'm glad I did that. So they make up for it.

MR: You've been involved in some jazz education projects?

HS: Yes. San Diego, the America's Finest City Dixieland Jazz Society has an adult jazz camp with instruction on cornet, trombone, reeds, piano, banjo, bass instruments and drums. And I've done one of those and was scheduled for a second and then had to go on one of these tours so I missed it. But I'll be doing it again this coming January. And I teach the older techniques: New Orleans, Chicago and the San Francisco/New Orleans revival style that I mentioned earlier.

MR: I'm glad you mentioned that because — is there a discernible difference between what happened to New Orleans jazz when it moved up to Chicago?

HS: There sure is. The New Orleans players who kept playing it in Chicago influenced the people in Chicago. I think the Chicago tradition was largely a dance band — hotel bands, dance bands, ragtime players — and when King Oliver's band went to Chicago, and before that Freddie Keppard with the Original Creole Band, they just showed a whole new way of playing. For instance I would doubt that there were a lot of bass players around Chicago who plucked the instrument. They probably bowed like every other bassist did, until Bill Johnson went there before World War I with Freddie Keppard and the Original Creole Band, and he was a sensation, and he had a feature number "Weary Blues" where he played chorus after chorus of slap string bass. So if you figure that's 1911 or 1913, that would turn the whole town over. And I think the New Orleans, Oliver and Armstrong, Johnny Dodds, Jimmy Noone, Baby Dodds, each of those people, and Jelly Roll Morton, they'd have an influence on the Chicago style that I think set a real course for it until Earl Hines and Bix changed it again. But I think there probably wouldn't be a "Chicago jazz" had it not been for the New Orleans players going there. Because that's what really turned on a lot of the players. In interviews with Goodman and Sullivan and Tough and all those guys, they said, "Well my influence was —" and almost in every case it was New Orleans musicians.

MR: Don't you kind of wish you could go back in time and witness some of that interaction?

HS: I'm ready. I'll go right now.

MR: Sometimes you feel like maybe you were born in the wrong era.

HS: I feel that way about twenty hours a day.

MR: Why is it that — I don't know if there's an answer to this question — but it seems that the music, the mainstream and the Dixieland is predominantly played by white players, and the audience for it too. And I sometimes wonder why.

HS: I wish I knew. If it's a matter of making money I can understand, because I don't know any wealthy jazz musicians. But I don't know lots of white musicians who've played blues or soul who have overseas tours and make lots of recordings. And you know I think it's a matter of going where the money is, and I can't blame anyone for that. I wish there were more black players, but the ones who play it tend to like, really, more modern styles — mainstream and beyond — rather than the earlier styles.

MR: Right. I guess the Joshua Redman and Christian McBride and that, those younger players, they do standards, but then they're more into I guess their own music, kind of breaking — I don't know if they're breaking ground or not.

HS: They probably are. And I think there's a number of musicians who play traditional jazz in concerts and tours and make recordings, but given their choice of what to play, that would not be what they want to play. They can make a certain good living doing that, but that's not their music. And I've witnessed that time and again. I know a trombone player in New Orleans, Freddie Lonzo, who is one of the few black players I've heard who really digs into the style and likes the style and is not on the bandstand like hoping to get off soon. I wish it wasn't that way. It's not been that way in the past, not until well into the '50s and the Bebop era. I mean we look at photos of jam sessions, at Jimmy Ryan's in the late '30s and '40s, I mean it's a total mixture. It's like nobody gave a second thought to that kind of thing, and it didn't really become that way until recent time, that I can tell. I mean I like playing, I've played where I've been the only white in the band, and I've been the drummer, and if there's a hot seat in an all black band, it's the drummer. But I had a ball. And the guys liked it. I thought I'm going to play for them, I'm not going to play what I think will work here. I tried that, it failed miserably. It was a supposed traditional jazz band. And I could hear a lot of swing influence in the players, but not the older styles. The older style just didn't work, it didn't set them off. So I thought all right, forget those people out there who are going to give me dirty looks in the audience. I'll just play what they want. So I laid in the rim shots and the ride cymbal, and took off. And I was accepted. And the next time I showed up they were all, "Hey, welcome back, man." So I just play for the band, and I know the people in the audience thought well that's not the correct set up that we want to see, what's that guy doing there? But I was there and I just made the best of it. But I have no problem with, I mean you can't make that a racial thing. If you make it into that, you're going to have a very unhappy bandstand. There's just no point in it.

MR: Right. Why back to New Orleans?

HS: Six nights a week of work.

MR: No kidding.

HS: Yes, from two nights a week to six nights a week.

MR: Are you lined up for that kind of work when you get back or do you just know it's there?

HS: Yeah. I took off from it to do this.

MR: I see.

HS: I mean I actually started it full time on August 29. And it's really my best friend in music, Chris Tyle, the trumpet player and cornet player. He's got a band called the Silver Leaf Jazz Band, at the Royal Sonesta Hotel in the Cancan Jazz Cafe. And I'm going to get in trouble for saying this, I think it's the only authentic New Orleans style band in the city, that really plays the music of King Oliver and Jelly Roll Morton, Armand Piron, Freddie Keppard, and plays it the way it was meant to be played, and not with modern chords and ride cymbal and all of that, it's very authentic.

MR: Well good for you. That should be doing what you want.

HS: It is. I really like it because he doesn't let it get boring. I mean he'll bring in new tunes to play and drop the ones that he's played a lot, and he's so versatile on the cornet, and can play all those different styles and make them fit. Whether it's Oliver or Muggsy Spanier or Keppard, Tommy Ladnier, or whatever, it's always the right thing. And that inspires me, when you've got a hot front line, you're not going to just sit there and take up space on the bandstand. You want to make it go.

MR: Gee I wonder if those bands ever do the wagon thing anymore, where they put the band on the wagon and they go out?

HS: What a great idea.

MR: Well they used to do that to advertise where they were playing.

HS: Sure.

MR: That's where the phrase "on the wagon" came from.

HS: And tailgate.

MR: And tailgate trombone.

HS: With the trombone hanging over the back. I'd love to play a job like that. I got a chance to play a parade down there, and for weeks, and this fellow Chris, who is also a fine drummer, we were going to play drums, bass drum and snare drum. We studied Bunk's Brass Band and the Eureka Brass Band, and we got all our sequence of parade beats down ready to go, and couldn't wait, oh boy, finally we were going to play a real parade in New Orleans. And we got down the street, literally rubbing our hands and waiting for the leader to give us the cue to bring it in. And he just picked up his clarinet and just started playing "The Saints." Too fast to march to.

MR: Oh, bummer.

HS: I've had one parade since then. It did work. It was a lot more in the tradition. But I'd love to play something like that on a horse drawn wagon or something. Disneyland used to do

that. Their main parade at Disneyland was down Main Street in horse drawn wagons. That's where I heard Kid Ory play.

MR: You've done quite a bit of band leading. What's the biggest headache in being a band leader? The biggest thing to surmount?

HS: Coordinating everyone's schedules. Because nobody can give their loyalty to one band. So when I, for instance with the Road Runners, Bobby Gordon's got his regular job in San Diego and now it's only two nights a week. But he also works with Marty Grosz and the Orphan Newsboys, and plays jazz parties as a solo. So I've got to coordinate that. Rebecca works all the time in Portland, freelance and with Dave Frishberg, and she's on this jazz party circuit. So that's enough right there. Then the other two guys are school teachers. "Well four days, well I can't really take off that long." So that's a problem. Then as soon as you start having subs, it changes the repertoire, it changes the sound, it changes everything. So the logistics are the worst part of it.

MR: And now you're going to be even more spread out, because you're going to be in New Orleans.

HS: Well I will, they won't. It will be one airfare from Gulfport, Mississippi now, instead of all of us being in a straight line down the west coast. But if somebody wants the band enough then I'll be able to pay that airfare I would think, I hope. But I think that's the worst headache. I mean none of it is important when you're up there playing and having a good time, and the people are reacting to it. The only other terrible headache is if it doesn't go over. But that's seldom. I mean how can you not like Rebecca's singing or Bobby's clarinet? I can't imagine that happening.

MR: You had mentioned talking about her that it was nice to work with, as you described, a singer who's a musician.

HS: Yes.

MR: Are there singers that aren't musicians?

HS: There are singers who don't play other instruments. They'll know the chords on a piano, or how to transpose — musical knowledge that everyone should have — but they don't think in instrumental terms. They're not thinking okay the band has just played a slow tune and now they're bringing me on, I'd better do something uptempo to bring the excitement level back up. They think okay, well I need this chord here, and then this chord here, and then lead me in here and I'll come in at this tempo, and then bring it up slightly and you can play this— and they don't think, by then you've lost the crowd. You've got to keep things going. I mean it doesn't have to be hyper, but I don't like long gaps between tunes, I don't like discussing routines. I want to know what's going to happen before we get on the stand. And that's why a singer like Rebecca, she's thinking that same way — well we'd better keep it moving. So if there's any question about the

chords on the verse or the set up, she'll say let's just start on the chorus, guitar and brushes, I'll just sing it. And it makes it easy, and it keeps things moving along. That's where a musician who is a vocalist is very handy.

MR: Cool. What's in the future as far as — you're joining a band down there, any other opportunities in surrounding New Orleans?

HS: Yeah. There's a lot of casual work, parties, weddings, things like that, and substitute work. You know some of the places go five days a week. One of the clubs has a shift of three bands on weekends. And sometimes people just get burned out and they want time off. Or they're going on vacation or something like that. So if I'm there I'll get a call. And recording work too. One of the labels I've done extensive recording for, Jazzology and GHB, it's based in New Orleans. And when I lived there before, I got the first call as a session drummer. So I would imagine I'll get that again.

MR: You've been on a lot of records already.

HS: Yeah. I think it's something like 125 counting videos and audio tapes and CDs and things like that.

MR: With the small labels, they pretty much pay you a set fee for your session?

HS: Yeah. You have to be on RCA or Sony, CBS, Verve, something like that, to get any kind of residual. I've gotten payments from the Recording Manufacturer's Fund, but that's the only kind of residual I ever get, unless I buy product at a discount and re-sell it on the job. Then you can make a little more that way. We get an artist discount when we buy our CD, so we're not paying full price. But still, we may have to play a local tax on it, or pay someone to handle it, so by the time I wind up with $7.50 to split five ways, none of us are getting rich on a CD sale.

MR: It's a crazy business.

HS: But I'll keep making them anyway. I mean I've made some I'm really, really proud of and in all different styles that I can play. I've done just about every drum style that I can play. A couple I've missed, but I imagine I'll get to them.

[audio interlude]

MR: Does this sound familiar to you?

HS: I recognize my splash cymbal.

MR: That's your splash cymbal?

HS: That's my splash cymbal. I only know a couple of other guys who would play it like that. That's a Rick Fay session for Arbors.

MR: Now on a session like this, I would imagine budget-wise you're fairly tight with the studio time?

HS: That one wasn't. Actually Arbors doesn't do that to musicians. Mat Domber is very loose about studio time and he doesn't want the music to be forced. And he's very fair in that respect.

MR: So you get in there and do a run through and then—

HS: You can do a run through and a couple of takes. I mean I don't think any producer would want you to do the rehearsal in the studio and then do multiple takes. I mean you have an idea of what you're going to do before you go in, but if it's a specially assembled band that's never seen the music, unless everybody's an ace sight reader, you're going to need some rehearsal time.

MR: And there's never, with this kind of music there's never overdubbing.

HS: Oh, sure.

MR: Oh, no kidding. So they isolate people in the studio?

HS: Not so much, no. What we've done a lot on sessions I've been involved in is if there's a vocal for instance, where you don't want to sing it live, you lay down the accompaniment beforehand. I mean say it's Rebecca, anyone that I would have on a recording session would know how she sings and her phrasing. Like Chris Tyle, the trumpet player. He'd lay down the accompaniment and then she can come in later with the headphones and lay down the track.

MR: No kidding?

HS: You don't like to do that, but there's times with brass or something it might be too loud for her to hear herself, and the iso booth doesn't — I hate that. If you can't have everybody grouped together in the studio like you would play on a bandstand, that's trouble just waiting to happen, because you can't make the eye contact or little hand signals or something, that might save a performance otherwise. But there is a fair amount of overdubbing and clipping on of endings, and now you can do it with a computer, just match up the sound waves of the cymbal crash and no one will ever know. I'll know but they won't.

MR: Right, that's okay. How do you feel about the future of this music — well I'm not sure what I mean by "this music" but—

HS: Well this pre-bebop music?

MR: Yeah.

HS: I'm worried to the point of ulcers about it. Because as our audience gets older I don't see a younger one coming up. There are plenty of youth education programs to teach young people to play this music, I don't know who they're going to play it for. I don't know of music appreciation courses or even public concerts to get more people interested in a style from Buddy Bolden to Bunny Berrigan. I mean the kids are going to have to find it on their own and say wow I'd like to play trumpet like that, and then in 2025 I'll say

good luck. I hope someone's there to listen to it. That really worries me. I mean you can see the age of the audience here, and they're great supporters, they go to all these things, they buy the recordings, they're the salt of the earth, but when they're gone, I don't know. And it's the same with the jazz festivals that I play on the west coast — the Dixieland festivals. An older crowd. If you add other music to bring in a younger crowd, you can add Zydeco and blues and Cajun music and things like that, but that's not jazz, that's not teaching them to appreciate Freddie Keppard or Bix or Earl Hines. So I don't know the answer to that except music appreciation courses starting right now, in as many places as possible.

MR: Right.

HS: Because there'll always be someone who'll say well I like that, I don't care to play it, I'd rather fiddle with my computer but I like the music and I'd go to hear it. I mean I hope that turns out that way.

MR: Yeah we definitely need more audience.

HS: It's different overseas, it really is. There's so many more people who really appreciate the music and know about it over there, and that's not changed since the twenties. The first books on jazz were from Europe.

MR: Right. We had a lot of our jazz musicians booking over there.

HS: Sure. And then they stayed there forever. I mean the black musicians who went there were treated like human beings and didn't have to look over their shoulder every time, and they had long and productive lives. Sidney Bechet is a God in France still. And I think that's too bad that in his own country he couldn't be treated that way.

MR: Well I'm hoping you don't have to move over there.

HS: Mississippi is about as far as I want to go.

MR: Okay. You can go for a visit.

HS: I'll come back.

MR: I want to thank you for sharing your time with us today.

HS: Thank you.

MR: And I hope you have a productive set tonight. I know you have to go and do your little talk-through rehearsal. And it's been a pleasure. Best of luck in your new environment down in the home of jazz. I hope to see you again.

HS: And likewise. Thanks so much.